

Care during pregnancy

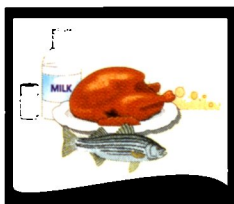
Congratulations! Becoming a mother is one of the most exciting times in a woman's life. With so many dreams to nurture and joys waiting to unfold. However, your delicate state of health brings anxieties too. Being fully informed about this antenatal period will ensure your health and that of your baby.

Follow a wise diet when pregnant

Eating the right foods is more important than ever. You don't need to 'eat for two'. A pregnant woman should eat a total of 2500 calories every day which is an extra 300 calories daily. These calories should come from a variety of healthy foods which would provide the right amount of proteins, vitamins and minerals.

Proteins

Proteins such as lean meat, fish, poultry without skin, eggs, nuts, dried beans, cheese, pulses and milk. Proteins build muscles, tissues, enzymes, hormones and antibodies for you and your baby. Protein rich foods also have vitamin B and iron, important for your blood.



Vitamins

- a) Folic Acid comes in Vitamin B group. Prevents neural tube defects i.e. defects in a baby's brain or spine, birth defects like cleft lip and congenital heart disease.

Folic acid should be started before you try to become pregnant. Sources are orange juice, spinach and legumes.

- b) Other vitamins come from eating fresh fruits, vegetables and whole grain cereals.

Vitamin B group is required for energy, foetal development, and formation of red blood cells.

Vitamin D is required for regulation of calcium metabolism and for bone and teeth development.

Vitamin E is a very important antioxidant.

Vitamin C is also an antioxidant important for growth.

Minerals

- a) Iron: Pregnant women require twice as much iron i.e. 30mg/day.

Sources: Lean red meat, fish, chicken, dried fruits, whole grain, green leafy vegetables, iron fortified cereals. Iron is required



for keeping blood healthy. Its deficiency causes anaemia, making you pale and tired.

- b) Calcium: Pregnant women require 1000mg of calcium per day.

Sources: Low fat milk, curd, cheese, green leafy vegetables, calcium fortified cereals.

- c) Zinc: Pregnant women require 15mg of zinc per day. Deficiency may lead to sub optimal growth of the baby.

Drinking adequate water is critical

A pregnant woman should drink at least 15 glasses of water daily. Water plays a key role in transporting nutrients from the food you eat to your baby. Also, it prevents constipation, haemorrhoids and urinary infections.

Having coffee, tea and soft drinks actually reduce the amount of fluid in your body. They don't count towards your water intake.

Weight gain during pregnancy is normal

The average weight gain during pregnancy is 12-16 kgs. 9 kgs accounts for the weight of the foetus, placenta, amniotic fluid, uterine hypertrophy, breast enlargement and increased extra cellular fluid. The remaining 3 kgs appears to be maternal storage fat.

Precautions for the sake of your little one!

1. Avoid excess salt.
2. Avoid alcohol as it can slow down baby's growth, affect the brain and cause birth defects.
3. Avoid foods that are greasy, fried and very spicy.
4. Avoid smoking, drugs and radiation.
5. Do not eat fish with high levels of mercury, such as shark, swordfish, mackerel. Instead, choose shrimp, salmon, catfish, light tuna.
6. Restrict your intake of caffeinated drinks, since excessive consumption can cause irritability, lack of sleep and low birth-weight babies.
7. If you have diabetes, maintain a balance of food, exercise and insulin, adopting a special meal plan. Get enough of folic acid.
8. Eat small, frequent meals instead of three large ones.
9. Don't go for long periods without eating.
10. Avoid strong and unpleasant odours.

While following these essential tips will ensure a healthy pregnancy, it is recommended that you visit your doctor for regular check-ups.